

ETHIOPIA Food Security Outlook

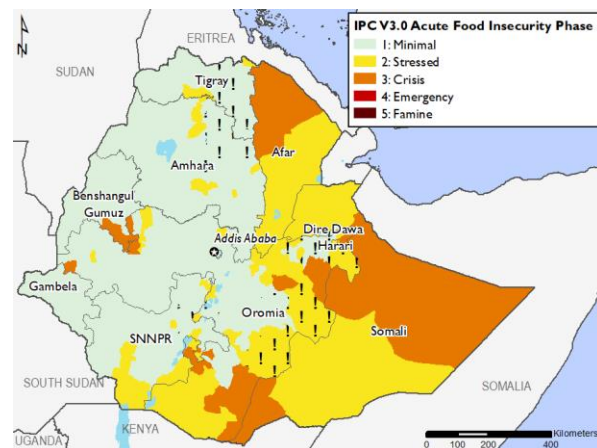
February to September 2019

The level of conflict-induced displacement needs begin to surpass drought-induced needs

KEY MESSAGES

- The average Meher harvest replenished household stocks in Meher producing parts of the central and western parts of the country and major portions of these areas of the country will remain in Minimal (IPC Phase 1) acute food insecurity from February to September 2019. Crisis (IPC Phase 3) outcomes are expected to continue, however, in southeastern and northeastern Ethiopia through September 2019 due to drought and conflict related displacement.
- In portions of the eastern lowlands of Oromia, eastern Amhara and southern Tigray, and conflict affected areas of SNNPR, and Oromia, Meher production is below average and access to food for the majority of households is constrained. These areas will be in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) between February and September 2019. Southern parts of SNNPR and Oromia, southern and central Afar, northern Somali region of Shinile zone and major parts of eastern Amhara and southeastern Tigray will remain in Stressed (IPC Phase 2) from February to September 2019.
- Conflict-induced displacement needs have increased across different parts of the country due to displacements that negatively affected households' access to food and income – according to DTM 14, more than 3 million people were displaced from their homes by the end of 2018. This displacement limits livelihoods opportunities and restricts humanitarian access. Some locations in Kemashe zone of Benshangul Gumuze, and Dawa zone of Somali region remain inaccessible until the end of 2018, hindering the delivery of much needed humanitarian assistance.

Current food security outcomes, February 2019



Source: FEWS NET

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NATIONAL OVERVIEW

Current Situation

Seasonal Progress: In northern pastoral and Agro-pastoral areas of Afar and Fafan Zones in Somali region, the anticipated near normal short light *Deda* rains did not occur in January 2019. Moreover, the similarly light *Sapie* rains around mid-January did not rain in SNNPR, though, unseasonal rain experienced in October and November 2018, helped to improve the local WRSI.

Most areas of the country that benefit from June to September 2018 *Kiremt* rains received average to above average rains. However, the lowlands of eastern Oromia, north eastern parts of Afar, eastern Amhara, and southern Tigray along the Tekeze catchment, experienced below normal cumulative and distribution of this rainfall. Despite sporadic atypical rain received in October 2018, these areas continue to be dominated by drier and hotter than normal climatic conditions.

From the beginning of January to March, the season in the southeastern pastoral area has been referred to locally as the long dry Jilal season. This dry season began after the area received below-average October – December 2018 *Deyr/Hageya* rainfall

and has resulted in limited regeneration of pasture and surface water in areas that are still recovering from the 2016/17 drought. Livestock from the nearby eastern areas where the Dyer rain season was below average migrated into the western livelihood zone that includes Filtu Dollo, Moyale Wayamo, and Afder Pastoral areas where pasture is relatively better - though this area is affected by ethnic tensions and is more insecure.

In eastern and central Somali region, due to the limited availability of pasture and water, livestock body conditions have started to deteriorate. As the long dry Jilal season progress, livestock body conditions will continue to further reduce, and livestock market supplies are expected to increase, while prices will reduce farther. Seasonal rainfall between March and May is critically needed to improve body conditions, increase conceptions and improve livestock prices.

In southern Afar and Sitti Zone of Somali Region (where seasonality is different than in the southeastern pastoral areas) poor households' livestock holdings remain lower than normal (as herd sizes have not fully recovered following significant losses during the El Niño-related drought in 2015), access to food and income from the sale of livestock remains below average. This is also true for Southern Oromia pastoral areas of Borana and Guji zones where by livestock holdings remain lower than normal as households are still recovering from the 2016/17 drought.

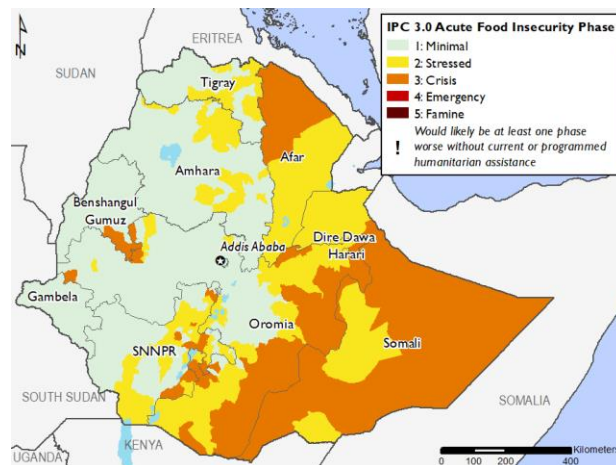
Recent Harvests: Overall national Meher crop production of 2018 is about average. Specifically, staple cereal crop production, mainly maize and sorghum, in most Meher-producing areas of Amhara, western Oromia Beshangul Gumuze, Gambela, Tigray, and western areas of SNNP regions is estimated to be average following the mostly favorable performance of the June to September 2018 Kiremt rainy season.

However, there are areas where below average production reported in some eastern parts of the country. According to data from the Meher seasonal assessments, conducted in November/December 2018 indicate that, Meher 2018 cereal production in the West Hararghe zones of Oromia Region were 6 and 44 percent lower than last year and the recent five-year average

respectively. In the north Wollo and Wag Himra Zones of Amhara Region, Meher 2018 production is estimated to be 44 and 31 percent lower than last year and the recent five-year average respectively. In the Wag Himra Zones of Amhara region, Meher 2018 production is estimated to be 6 percent higher than in 2017 and 42 percent lower than the five-year average. In the lowland areas of eastern and central Oromia, the lowland parts of Wag Himra Zone in Amhara Region, and localized areas of the Tekeze River catchments in Tigray Region, *Meher* 2018 production was below average.

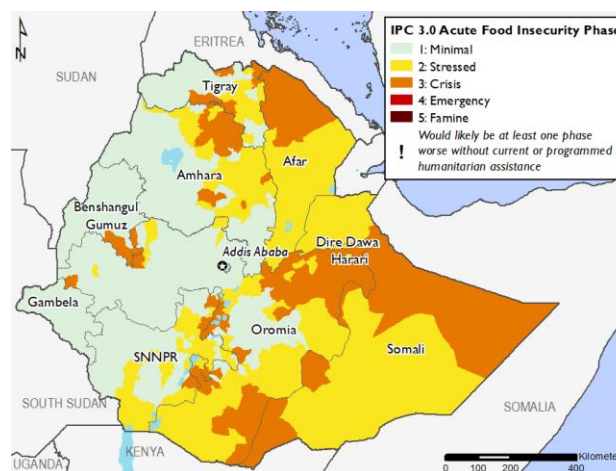
Chat and other irrigated periodic, annual, and perennial crops, vegetables, and fruits produced in East and West Hararghe zones of Oromia, Enset in Sidama, and Gedio Zone of SNNPR, were affected by frost, especially in the high and midlands. More than 18,000, and 14,958 hectares of enset from Sidama, and West Hararghe zones, respectively, were severely affected by the frost.

Projected food security outcomes, February to May 2019



Source: FEWS NET

Projected food security outcomes, June to September 2019



Source: FEWS NET

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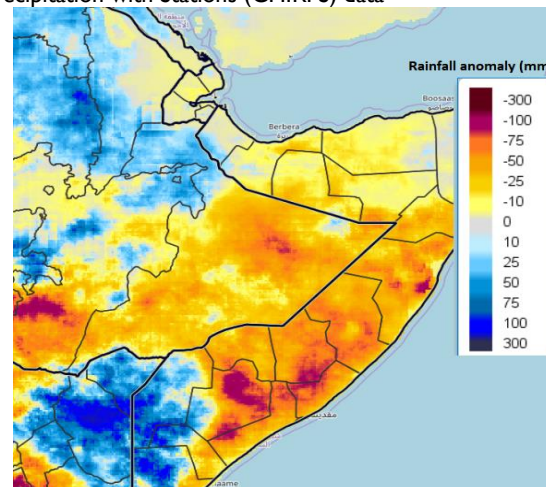
The combination of erratic distribution of rainfall in some lowland areas of Haraghe, SNNPR, and parts of Amehara and Tigray, an infestation of Yellow Rust in the highland areas of Oromia and Amhara, unseasonable rains in October/November 2018, and conflicts among the different ethnic groups resulted in below-average total production in all crop types. However, crops like maize, sorghum, wheat and barley are the most affected crops.

In Western and southwestern parts of the country, production of perineal crops including coffee, enset, and tree fruits are average to above-average due to generally conducive weather conditions. Similarly, most households obtained average to above-average production from root crops such as sweet potato, taro, and cassava. However, despite sweet potatoes planted in November 2019 having normal growth through January, due to the failure of Sapie rains in January the plants have started wilting and will be damaged severely if the Belg 2019 rains do not start early in southwestern SNNPR.

Markets: Prices for major staple foods (sorghum, maize, and wheat grain) did not decline across most markets between December 2018 and January 2019, in line with seasonal trends due to conflict that disrupted markets combined with increase in transportation cost and low supply to the market in the eastern parts of the country where production was below average. Wholesale prices for sorghum were 10 to 20 and wheat grain were 30 to 40 percent above prices from January 2018 and the five-year average, respectively, in most major markets.

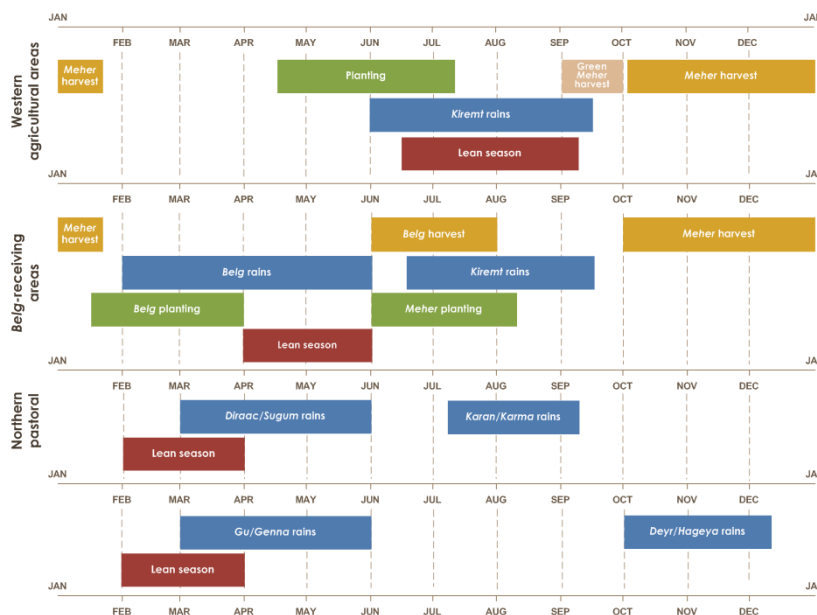
In the eastern lowlands including east and west Hararghe, Dire Dewa, northern Somali and Harare Region, sorghum and maize are the major staples though production, specially of sorghum, in these areas did not meet local needs. Higher proportions of households are relying on cereals supplied from other parts of the country. Currently, sorghum prices are high. For example, compared to January 2018 and the five-year average, sorghum prices are 47.2 and 45 percent higher, respectively.

Figure 1. October to December 2018 rainfall, anomaly in millimeters (mm) as a standard deviation (SD/z-score) from 2000-2018 mean using Climate Hazards Group Precipitation with Stations (CHIRPS) data



Source: USGS/FEWS NET

SEASONAL CALENDAR FOR A TYPICAL YEAR



Source: FEWS NET

In central, northern, and southwestern parts of the country, supplies of food grain to the market seasonally increased following the Meher harvest in November and December 2018. However, the price of staple food remains stable compared to the

December 2018 and that of last year, but much higher than the five-year average. The price of wholesale maize in February in Hosanna market is 6, 1, and 30 percent higher than January 2019, February 2019 and the five-year average, respectively. When we see Ethiopian Trade and Business Corporation (ETBC) December 2018 sorghum price in Gonder market, Amhara Region,

about nine and 74 percent higher than November 2018 and last five-year average price respectively. Similarly, ETBC price data for the month of December 2018 sorghum price at Mehoni market in Tigray was about, 61 and 64 percent higher December 2017 and last five-year average price respectively.

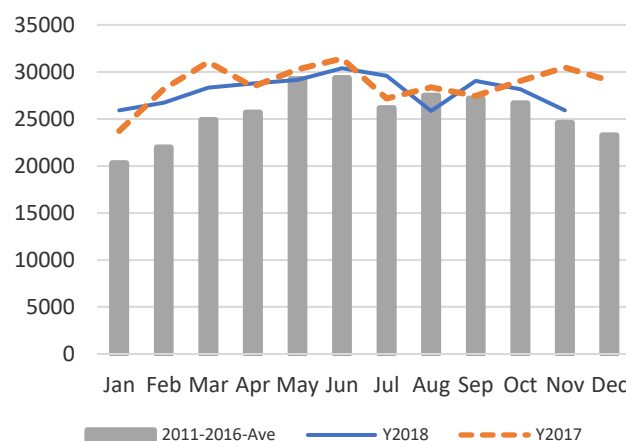
Staple food prices have increased primarily because of sporadic civil unrest that disrupts market functioning and transportation of cost, in combination with fuel prices and the continued inflation of the Ethiopian birr.

Livestock prices in southern pastoral areas are still stable while prices in central, northern and western areas are seeing improvements owing in part to the availability and regeneration of pasture and rangeland that helps to improve body conditions. Prices are below-average in parts of southeastern Somali as rangeland regeneration and water availability remains too low to improve livestock body conditions. For example, according to the Woreda Disaster Risk Management (DRM) office, goat prices in Chiro (west Hararghe) market were 25 percent higher in December 2018, compared to last year and 29 percent higher compared to the five-year average. In Gode -Shebele and Fike- Negobe markets, prices for average-sized locally consumed goats were reduced by 12.5 and 9 percent in December 2018 and January 2019 compared to September to October 2018 price respectively.

Nutrition: Admissions into therapeutic feeding programs (TFP) remain above the six years average (2011-2016) across the country. In Somali Region overall, TFP admissions in October 2018 reached more than 6,673, which is 12 percent lower than in October 2017 but 198 percent higher than the six-year average.

Humanitarian Assistance: The level conflict-induced displacement needs have increased in 2019 compared to previous years, contributing more than a third of the acute food insecure population in the country. As reported by IOM-DTM round 14, conflict across different parts of the country currently become the leading cause of displacement for more than 3 million people. Since the release of DTM R14 report, there were new clashes in Central Gondar, Amhara region between in February 2019 which resulted in the displacement of more than 44,708 individuals as per IOM DTM summary of Reports for the period from February 9-15, 2019. There are also areas that were not accessed by IOM including Dawa Zone of Somali and Kemashe Zone of Beshangul

Figure 2. TFP admissions in Somali Region



Source: ENCU

Table 1: Number of people in need of humanitarian food assistance from January to June 2019

Table 1: Number of People in Need of humanitarian Food assistance

Region	People in acute need in million	People in Midrate need in million	Total people in need in million	People in need vs. Total population in percent
Oromia	2.56	1.88	4.44	12
Somali	0.33	1.67	2.00	34
SNNP	0.56	0.21	0.77	4
Amhara	0.26	0.33	0.59	3
Tigray	0.18	0.10	0.28	5
Afar	0.09	0.15	0.24	13
Benishagul Gumz	0.20	0.01	0.21	19
Gambela	0.022	0.008	0.03	6
Dire Dawa	0.003	0.015	0.018	4
Harari	0.001	0.04	0.041	2
Total People in Need of Food assistance	4.18	4.35	8.53	

Source: UN OCHA

Gumize, that have an undetermined number of displaced people. These displacements, limits livelihoods opportunities and restrict access to humanitarian support. 44,708 individuals displaced from Central Gonder zone of Amhara region (East Dembia, West Dembia, chilga and Tseged Woredas) were reported to be within the same region (East Dembia, West Dembia, chilga and Lay Armacheho woredas). All the sites are accessible and the zonal and woreda administrations reported that the IDPs are in need of shelter and NFIs.

In Dawa zone of Somali region, and Kemashe zone of Benshangul Gumuze, conflict has prevented humanitarian actors from doing an assessment and delivering much needed assistance since March 2018 in Dawa zone and October 2018 in Benishangul Gumuz to the end of year 2018.

However, in Dawa zone of Somali region WFP was able to begin distribution of food in 2019 following eleven months of disruptions due to insecurity in the region. Since January 15th, they have delivered over 1,000 metric tons of food to just under 200,000 beneficiaries in the zone.

The 2019 Humanitarian Response Plan released on March 7th estimates a total of 8.1 million people (2.8 million displaced persons, and 5.2 million non-displaced persons) will require humanitarian food assistance between February and June 2019. The breakdown of humanitarian food assistance needs estimates by region is follows: 46 percent in Oromia, 22 percent in Somali, 12 percent in Amhara, 10 percent in SNNP, 4 percent each in Tigray and Afar regions, and the remaining beneficiaries comprise those in Gambela, Benishangul Gumuz, Harari and Dire Dawa. However, the Response Plan does not show the requirement of assistance by IPC Phase (magnitude of the problem)

Assumptions

The most-likely scenario from February to September 2019 is based on the following national-level assumptions:

Agroclimatology:

- The *Gu/Genna*/long rains (March to May 2019) are likely to be average with localized areas of dryness, based on the forecasted persistence of the ongoing El Niño through the March-April-May period, as well as neutral tending to positive IOD neutral over the Indian Ocean.
- *Belg* (February to May 2019) rainfall is most likely to be average in *Belg*-producing areas of southwestern, central and northern Ethiopia.
- The *Dirac/Sugum* rains (March to May 2019) in northern pastoral areas of Ethiopia are likely to be average.
- *Kiremt* (June to September 2019) seasonal rainfall in Ethiopia is expected to be average.
- *Karan/Karma* (July to September 2019) seasonal rainfall in Ethiopia is expected to be average.

Pastoral Conditions:

- In southeastern pastoral areas of Somali Region, southern Oromia, and southern SNNPR, pasture and water availability will begin to improve temporarily following the onset of *Gu* rainfall in March. The expected average *Gu* rains will result in average regeneration of water and pasture, which will support pasture and water needs of pastoralists and livestock during the dry season (between July and September 2019).
- In northern pastoral areas of Afar and northern Somali, pasture and water availability will improve following the onset of *Sugum/Dirac* rainfall in March. The expected average *Sugum/Dirac* rains will support average levels of water and pasture availability, although forecasted hotter-than-normal temperatures through June 2019 will lead to earlier than normal deteriorations pasture and water conditions.
- Livestock body conditions, production and productivity in northern pastoral areas will remain average throughout the scenario period. However, in southern and southeastern pastoral areas of the country, livestock body conditions and productivity will likely remain below average until the start of the *Deyr/Hageya* rains in October 2019.

Agriculture:

- *Belg* harvests starting in June expected to be near average in Belg-producing areas of SNNPR, parts of Gambella, and northern parts of the country such as eastern Amhara and southern Tigray.

Markets:

- Supplies of staple cereals on markets are expected to remain at seasonally normal levels in most parts of Amhara, Tigray, SNNPR and Oromia following the normal/average Meher 2018 harvests in most major cereal-producing areas of the country. However, sporadic and localized conflicts and continuous inflation of Ethiopian currency are likely to affect the supply to the local and national market. Moreover, staple cereals market supply will seasonally diminish prior to the start of Meher harvests in October 2019. Thus, staple cereals Market prices expected to remain at somewhat above average levels between February and September 2019.
- Livestock prices are expected to be normal to above normal following the expected average Gu/Gena/long, Belg, Dirac/Sugum, Karan/Karma and Kiremt rains which will improve pasture and water availability that will in turn improve livestock body conditions.

Labor Opportunities:

- With an average performance of Belg rains, pre-harvest (planting and weeding) agricultural labor opportunities in Belg producing areas of the country are likely to be normal from February to May 2019. Moreover, due to the expected average Kiremt rains, agricultural labor opportunities are likely to be normal from June to September 2019 in Kiremt producing areas, resulting in average income from agricultural labor.

Nutrition:

- Acute watery diarrhea cases are likely to increase in parts of Somali, eastern Oromia, Afar, and Amhara Regions between February and September 2019, due to open water sources for human and animal consumption, potential risk of flooding and water shortages associated with warmer-than-normal surface temperatures over eastern and northern parts of the country, during the on-going dry season.
- PSNP resources are planned, funded, and likely to be transferred for about eight million chronically food insecure people in eight regions of the country for six rounds between January-June 2019. PSNP resource are expected to be a combination of cash and food grain.

Humanitarian Assistance:

- As per unofficial information from National Disaster Risk Management Commission (NDRMC,) and UNOCHA, Humanitarian Requirements estimate a total of 8.1 million people will require humanitarian food assistance between January and June 2019. Accordingly, between February and June 2019, JEOP, WFP, and NDRMC assistance is expected to address the need for the figure mentioned above, although delivery of this assistance is likely to be irregular and delayed. For the purposes of this scenario, no assistance is assumed beyond June as the appeal is expected to be revised after the Belg season and is yet to be funded. Though beneficiaries are not categorized by different level of IPC, the Government of Ethiopia through its NDRMC, expected to prioritize humanitarian assistance in the absence of full funding in order to prevent a more severe deterioration of outcomes.
- Humanitarian partners in Ethiopia will continue to face access challenges for conflict related IDPS due to security related violence and tension for humanitarian assistance

Displacement:

- Sporadic, localized conflict is likely to continue and to lead to additional displacement between February and September, in different parts of the country including along the Oromia and Somali, Oromia and Benishangul, Oromia and SNNPR, Afar and Somali and Amhara and Tigray Regional borders.

Most Likely Food Security Outcomes

As a result of below-average household access to food and income, households in the eastern half of the country will likely face livelihoods protection deficits and moderate food consumption gaps between February and May 2019. With forecasts for near average March to May 2019 Genna/Gu rains, pastoral conditions, livestock body conditions, productivity, and prices will improve, which in turn slightly improve household access to food through purchase and nutritional statuses until the end of the dry season in September 2019.

Households food security is expected to remain stable from January to September 2019 particularly in the western and central surplus-producing areas of Oromia, western parts of SNNPR, Amhara, Gambela, Tigray and Benishangul Gumuz owing in part to the near-average October 2018- January 2019 *Meher* production. This has produced favorable pasture conditions that will address their food and non-food needs from their own production and from normal access to income from *Meher* crop and livestock sales. Thus, major portions of these areas of the country will remain in Minimal (IPC Phase 1) acute food insecurity from February to September 2019.

In Southeastern pastoral areas of the country (eastern parts of Somali), lowlands of Oromia (east and west Hararghe zones), northeastern Afar, Tekeze catchment areas of Amhara and Tigray, conflict affected areas of southern pastoral areas (Dawa Zone of Somali and Borena of Oromia), areas bordering Guji zone of Oromia and Liben and Afder zones of Somali, areas bordering Guji zone of Oromia and Gedio Zone of SNNPR, Kemashe Zone of Bshangul Gumuze bordering east and west Wollega Zone of Oromia and Cental Gondar Zone of Amhara) food access for poor and very poor households is currently constrained. Poor livestock body conditions have led to reductions in livestock to cereals terms of trade and low access to milk in pastoral areas. These households also face below-average production of staple foods, earlier than normal exhaustion of food stocks, in addition to significantly lower than normal access to income from harvest labor in agricultural areas, and intermittent ethnic clashes that erode farmers' and pastoralists' livelihoods. As a result, the majority of these areas will be in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) between February and September 2019.

However, southern and southeastern pastoral areas will likely see improved livestock body conditions, which will improve cash income and milk access for households, following the anticipated average Gana/Gu rain from March to May 2019. As a result, food security is expected to improve from Crisis (IPC phase 3) to Stressed (IPC Phase 2) between June and September 2019 in central Somali and areas bordering Oromia and Somali region. Southern parts of SNNPR, Oromia, southern and central Afar, northern Somali region of Shinile zone and eastern Amhara and southern Tigray will remain in Stressed (IPC Phase 2) from February to September 2019.

AREAS OF CONCERN

Northern AgroPastoral (NAP) Livelihood Zone -Lowlands of Eastern Oromia (East and West Hararghe zones)

Current Situation

Agroclimatology: The lowlands of eastern Oromia experienced poor cumulative rainfall and distribution during the June to September (Kiremt 2018) rains when total rainfall was 55 to 70 percent of normal according to USGS/CHIRPS. Despite the few sporadic and atypical rainfall events in October 2018, these areas continue to be dominated by dryness and hotter than normal climatic conditions.

Meher 2018: Planting of Meher 2018 crops were favored by precipitation from the Belg 2018 early rains. However, as Kiremt rains did not progress normally, crop growth and development were constrained by moisture deficits. Planting coverage though was significantly higher than last year: 43 percent higher in Golo Oda woreda and 88 percent higher in Meyu Mulke woreda. However, substantial portions of the planted fields were damaged

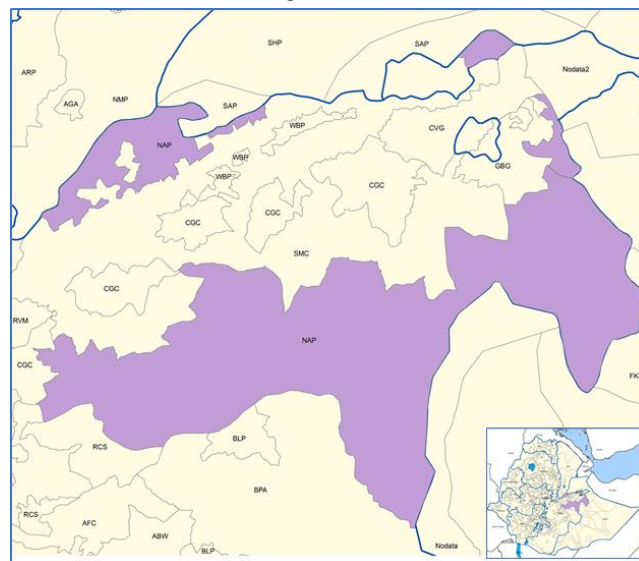
in their early growth stages and farmers had to replant with shorter-maturing and lower-yielding crops. Overall, production in all the Woredas in the administration zone was reportedly better than last year. Nonetheless, production in the lowland parts of the Northern Agro-Pastoral (NAP) Livelihood Zone remained well below normal, and according to the recent multi-agency seasonal assessment report, Meher 2018 production was 53 percent lower in Meyu Muluke woreda and 57 percent lower in Golo Oda woreda compared to the reference year.

Pastoral Conditions: Intermittent dry spells in June and August 2018 resulted in the deterioration of livestock feed and water supplies. However, livestock feed from unproductive crops and the addition of atypical rains in October 2018 helped pastures regenerate and improved livestock body conditions. Despite this, household's livestock holding were still low due to the impacts of past seasons' poor rainfall, and more seasons will be needed for further herd size improvement and recovery. Conflict incidences and tensions along the Somali Region border have also restricted pastoralists movements.

Staple Food Prices: As local production of local staples, sorghum and maize, are insufficient to satisfy household needs, households are relying on market purchases of staple cereals from the central and western parts of the country. Currently, prices for both staples are elevated, though more so for sorghum. December 2018 whole sale price data from ETBC in Dire Dawa market indicated that sorghum prices increased by 47.2 and 45 percent compared to last year and five-year average price respectively. According to the Chiro woreda DRM office price data, retail prices of goats at the Chiro market increased slightly in December 2018 and were 25 and 29 percent higher than last year last five-year average respectively. This results in unfavorable terms of trade for pastoralists.

Nutrition: Scabies, which is caused by poor water access and lack of sanitation, continues to be the primary health concern in the lowlands of East Haraghe, and is negatively affecting the nutritional status of children and lactating mothers. Overall, the nutrition status for children under five year of age (U5) showed deterioration according to the data from SAM admissions and MAM screenings from ENCU. In October 2018 in East Hararghe zone 2,747 children U5 SAM admissions were reported which was 16 percent higher than in October 2017. Within East Hararghe, the woredas in the lowlands of East Hararghe (NAP livelihood zone) have higher rates of malnutrition than those in the mid and high lands, according to the zonal health office. The October 2018 children under five (U5) SAM admissions in the NAP Woredas of Golo Oda (229), Melka Belo (163) and Midega Tola (152).

Figure 3. Reference map, Northern Agro-Pastoral (NAP) Livelihood Zone, Oromia region



Source: FEWS NET

Data from October 2018 in Woredas outside of the NAP livelihood zone shows lower admission numbers, for example, in Goro Gutu and Babile woredas, U5 SAM admissions were 55 children per woreda.

Internal Displacement: This livelihood zone shares a long border with the Somali region and border conflict and tensions are the primary sources of IDPs. Additionally, displaced persons are arriving in the zone from Somali Region and Djibouti. Currently, there are 405,435 IDPs in East and West Hararghe zone which is the greatest number of conflict-induced IDPs in the Oromia Region. Many of the IDPs are living in woredas in the lowlands of Oromia where WFP has been supplying food aid.

Humanitarian Assistance: As of December 2018, in addition to the 405,435 IDPs, a little over 1.1 million people were being assisted thorough emergency food assistance program in East and West Hararghe zones, mostly in the lowlands. The distribution is scheduled for monthly delivery but some irregularities have occurred. and recently beneficiaries had to wait more than two months to receive a round of emergency food assistance. WFP's Productive Safety Nets Program (PSNP) 2019 first round transfer has started in many woredas.

In general, Meher 2018 had meager production and mostly benefitted the middle and better off households who harvested a significant portion of it. Livestock feed availability from unproductive crops and pasture regeneration from the atypical rains received in October 2018 are improving livestock body conditions and in turn their prices. However, low livestock holdings by the poor and very poor due to protracted drought and livestock death in past seasons, has constrained access to typical income. In a normal year, prices of staple cereals at this time of the year would be seasonally low. However, prices of staple foods this year are unusually high. Thus, households are unable to meet consumption requirements and will remain in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) between February and May 2019.

Assumptions

The most likely scenario for the February to September 2019 period is based on the following area level assumptions:

Agroclimatology:

- The March to May (Belg 2019) climate forecast issued by the National Meteorological Agency (NMA) indicates there is an increased likelihood of having average Belg 2019 rains in most parts of East and West Haraghe. However, in view the current and projected El-Nino and due to the inter-seasonal variability of the Belg season, erratic temporal and spatial distribution of rainfall is most likely.
- Belg 2019 rains are only expected to favor land preparation and planting of long-cycle crops.

Household Stocks:

- Households are likely to exhaust food from Meher 2018 production two to three months earlier than normal in April/May 2019.

Pastoral Situation:

- Restricted movements of pastoralists and their livestock due to fear of conflict along the Somali border will continue.
- Following the start of April/May Belg 2019 rains livestock feed, and water condition will steadily improve which in turn will improve livestock body conditions.

Sources of Income:

- Agricultural labor opportunities for poor households are expected to improve following the Belg 2019 rains and will continue throughout the scenario period.

Staple Food Prices:

- Staple food prices will start to seasonally increase beginning in May 2019 from their already escalated current prices.

Most Likely Food Security Outcomes

Food stocks from the meager Meher 2018 harvest is expected to exhaust earlier than normal in February/ March 2019. Households continue to suffer from lower than usual livestock holdings due to impacts of past drought seasons as well as reduced livestock prices during the dry period prior to the expected start of the Belg 2019 rains in April/May 2019. Marginal improvements in food availability and seasonally cheaper staple food prices are not enough to reduce household food consumption gaps. PSNP resources will narrow food consumption gaps of chronically vulnerable households, but some food consumption gaps are likely to persist for acutely affected households and they will continue to be in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) between February and May 2019.

The 2019 Belg rains will bring some agricultural labor opportunities, and the rains in April/May 2019 are expected to favor improved livestock body conditions and livestock production. Income from livestock sales will be low during this period. Food access from market will begin to worsen starting in April as staple prices rise. Thus, poor households who typically rely on markets for food will face increased food consumption gaps and will remain in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) from June to September 2019.

Moyale Wayamo Pastoral (MWP) livelihood zone

Current Situation

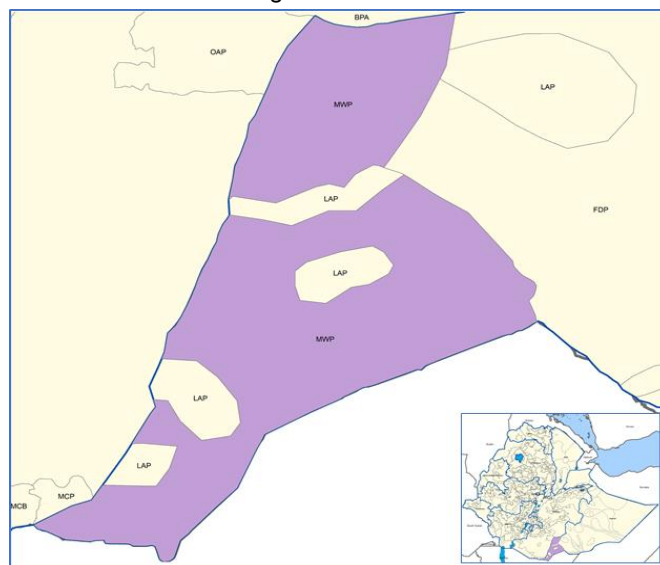
Agroclimatology: The 2018 Dyer rainy season had a timely onset over most parts of the Moyale Wayamo Pastoral livelihood zone (MWP). However, it has been characterized by extended dry spells in October and November for about 12-18 days each and erratic temporal and spatial distribution.

Despite this, the cumulative rainfall during the season across the livelihood zone is better than in other parts of the region and which improved pasture and grazing lands. This helped to improve livestock body conditions, which in turn helped livestock conception and birth rates, and livestock products, especially milk availability. In the 2018 Deyr season the livelihood zone received good rainfall following better rain during the Gu 2018.

Pastoral and Livestock Conditions: Favorable rains helped to have two cycles of small ruminants (goats and sheep) and one cycle of large livestock (camels and cattle) births during 2018 which will help the households in the livelihood zone to marginally recover from the 2016/2017 livelihood losses. However, despite this improvement, herd sizes remain below average compared to the reference year, due to higher than usual livestock sales to fulfill food needs (as there was no humanitarian food assistance delivery in the area due to security related issues) and repayment of debt from the 2016/17 drought period. According to the Deyr 2018 assessment findings, herd sizes were reduced by 20, 34 and 30 percent for camels, cattle and shoats, respectively. The same report also indicated a reduction in the number of milking animals and daily milk yield by 35 and 22 percent for camels, and 25 and 20 percent for shoats, respectively.

Pastureland and water availability are expected to be maintained for only one month. However, livestock from nearby areas where the recent Dyer rain season was below-average are migrated into the livelihood zone and this will exhaust the feed and water resources sooner than normal.

Figure 4. Reference map, Moyale Wayamo Pastoral (MWP) Livelihood Zone, Somali region



Source: FEWS NET

Livestock prices: Moyale livestock market, the second largest livestock market in southern Ethiopia, is nearly closed due to the prevailing conflict between Oromo and Somali ethnic groups. This ethnic clash continues to constrain pastoral and agropastoral households' access to markets to sell their livestock and buy food and non-food staples. Both livestock and cereal supplies are abnormally low and cereal prices outside the normal market center within the livelihood zone have risen significantly. For example, maize prices in December 2018 in Filtu market were 33 percent higher than the same period last year and 55 percent higher than the five year average. This forced pastoralists in the livelihood zone to rely primarily on imported food items from Kenya. However, imported commodities in the livelihood zone have become increasingly more expensive in recent months because of the road blocks by the Kenyan Government at the border due to security concerns.

Conflict and Displacement: The intertribal conflict that have been ongoing intermittently for more than a year between the Somali and Oromo communities, most recently in December 2018 was widespread in range with major eruptions of violence reported in most parts of the border woredas of Borana and Liban zones. This caused pastoralist and agropastoral communities to flee for safety towards the eastern part of the livelihood zone, causing a concentration of livestock in a limited area. Asset destruction, burning of homes and local infrastructure, and looting of livestock changed the livelihood settings of the affected pastoral households. They were observed establishing a settlement (IDP camps) near towns with no shelter, food, and water making livelihoods coping difficult. These IDPs have lost all or part of their livestock and important assets like arable land and were therefore not able to benefit from the improved rains in the area. According to the DTM round 14 (November-December 2018), the total IDP population displaced in December 2018 in the newly established Dawa Zone (Moyale, Hudet, Mubarak and Qadhadhumo Woredas) that comprises the MWP livelihood zone, was more than 276,089.

Humanitarian Assistance: Access for humanitarian actors to this livelihood zone to assess the conditions of and provide humanitarian assistance for affected pastoralists was impossible until the end of November 2018. However, according to the most recent information from the Woredas the regional Government, WFP and Save the children International (SCI) were able to access the area in December 2018. SCI was able to distribute 60MTs of TSFP ration and WFP was able to deliver one round of food aid in December 2018 and January 2019. The regional government was also able to deliver rice and oil for the IDPs in December 2018 and January 2019.

Assumptions

The most likely scenario for the February to September 2019 period is based on the following area level assumptions:

Agroclimatology:

- Cumulative rainfall during the Gu/Gena long rains from March to May 2019 are likely to be average,

Pastoral and Livestock Conditions:

- Availability of water and pasture will improve with the Gu rainfall between March and May 2019.
- Gu rains will improve pasture availability and livestock body conditions and will improve income from livestock sales.
- Goats that conceived during the Deyr 2018 season will give birth during the Gu 2019 season, when milk production will improve slightly.
- Despite additional livestock births during the Gu season, livestock herd sizes are likely to remain very low. This will limit households' ability to sell additional livestock in order to increase access to income and will result in continued low total milk production at the household level.

Markets:

- Market supplies of staple cereals are expected to remain high in most parts of the livelihood zone and in the Somali Region in general.

Nutrition:

- Low availability of water for human consumption is likely to increase the risk of disease outbreaks, particularly Acute Watery Diarrhea (AWD), for which cases are expected to increase during the July to September dry season in IDP camps.

Conflict and Displacement:

- Sporadic, localized conflict is likely to continue and to lead to additional displacement between February and September 2019 along the Somali Oromia and Somali Afar Borders.
- Humanitarian partners will continue to face access challenges for conflict related IDPS in the livelihood zone due to security related violence and tension.

Most Likely Food Security Outcomes

Household food access from available markets and their own food stocks are significantly reduced due to low herd size, affecting available salable livestock, high staple food prices, and low household cash income from self-employment and labor. Following herd size reductions due to the previous drought years, the amounts and types of gifts that poor and very poor households received from middle and better off households declined dramatically. Conflicts that hinder the movement of livestock in search of pasture and water contribute to the declining daily milk yield in this livelihood zone. Conflict also disrupted pastoral livelihoods and markets for the sale of livestock and the purchase of staple foods. Thus, the food consumption gap is likely to persist for poor and very poor households and will put them in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) from February to May 2019.

Following the anticipated average, March to May 2019 Gu rains, camels and shoats that conceived during the 2018 Gu, and shoats that conceived during the 2018 Deyir are expected to give birth which should lead to marginal milk production in the season. However, as markets are disrupted, income from livestock product sales may not improve. On the other hand, high staple cereal prices are expected to continue to constrain household food access at markets, reduced herd sizes from the 2016/2017 drought are still pronounced, and a large number of IDPs are present in the zone. The combined effects of these natural and man-made shocks have deprived households of food and income access that they would normally have from their livelihoods. Therefore, poor and very poor households in this area are expected to remain in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) through September 2019.

Tekeze Sorghum and Goat (TSG) livelihood zone

Current Situation

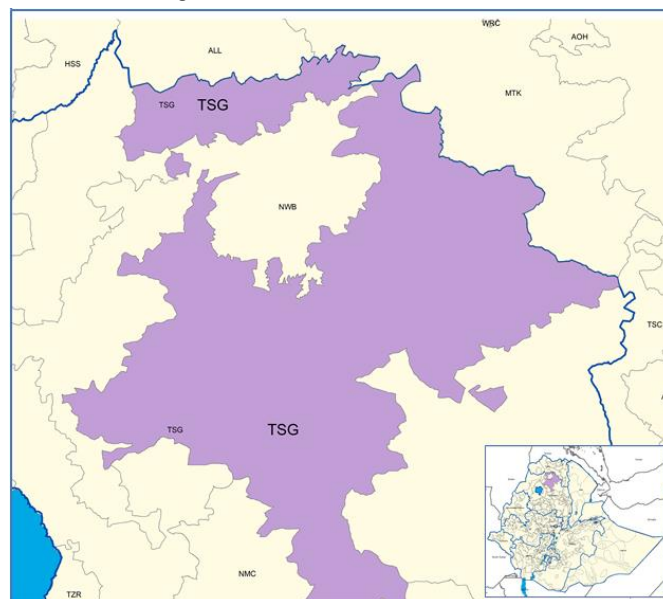
Currently food access from own production have improved in most areas of the livelihood zone and the northeastern Amhara and Tigray regions following the fair 2018 Meher harvest. However, staple food prices did not show the expected level of seasonal decline due to below average Meher production associated with very poor performance of Sorghum crops in the lowland areas and insecurity related road blockages that blocked food transported from other areas. On the other hand, livestock prices have improved, though the poor and the very poor who have fewer livestock holdings are not benefiting from these price improvements. This has limited the purchasing power of poor and very poor households. Thus, the poor and very poor households, particularly in the TSG livelihood zone, can marginally meet their food consumption needs and are currently in Stressed (IPC phase 2) in February 2019.

Agroclimatology: The Northeastern Amhara and Tigray Regions received average to above-average cumulative Meher rainfall between July and September 2018. However, the spatial and temporal distribution were irregular, particularly in the lowland areas along the Tekeze catchment of Wag Himra North and eastern Gonder Zones of Amhara and Southern Tigray. Moreover, Kiremt 2018 seasonal rainfall ceased between the end of August and early September 2018, which was about one to two weeks early and most crops were at the flowering and seed setting stages. Unseasonable rainfall between the end of October and November 2018 affected matured crops in lowland and midland areas of the Tekeze catchment and the TSG livelihood zone and resulted in the sprouting of seed grains in the agricultural fields.

The unseasonable rainfall between the end of October and November 2018 also contributed to better pasture and water availability in most parts of eastern Amhara and Southern Tigray. As a result, livestock feed, water availability and livestock body conditions are normal. However, livestock across the TSG livelihood zone, in pockets of north and south Wello, north and central Gonder, and some lowland areas in southern Tigray, have only limited crop stocks and pasture resources for livestock feed, and it is expected to be exhausted soon.

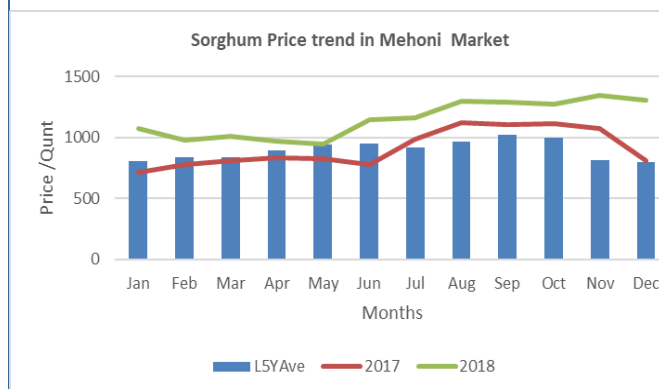
Staple Food Prices: In January and February 2019, supplies of locally-produced staple foods, such as sorghum, maize and wheat were seasonally stable due to the recent Meher harvest, but they did not show the expected seasonal price decline because of the below average production in the area. As a result, according to the ETBC sorghum prices in November 2018 in Gonder market in Amhara were 9 and 74 percent higher than the previous month and the five-year average respectively. Similarly, ETBC data indicates that December 2018 sorghum prices at Mehoni market in Tigray were 61 and 64 percent higher than last year and the five-year average respectively.

Figure 5. Tekeze Lowland Sorghum and Goat (TSG) (Livelihood Zone, Amhara region



Source: FEWS NET

Figure 6. Sorghum price trends in Mehoni Market, Tigray region

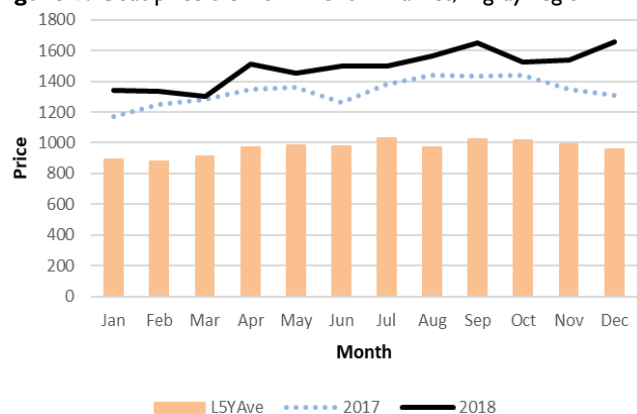


Source: FEWS NET

Livestock Prices: Livestock supplies at markets remain normal in all markets in eastern Amhara and southern Tigray regions. However, the impact of continuous increases in food items and continuous livestock meat demand in nearby towns, local festivals in the rural areas and improved body conditions of livestock, is maintaining higher than usual livestock prices. For example, an average sized goat at the Mehoni market in December 2018 was sold for about 7, 27 and 73 percent more than compared to November 2018, December 2017, and the five-year average respectively.

Displacement: Currently there are more than 77,000 IDPs in Tigray and 75,000 IDPs in Amhara region (not including the very recent displaced people in Central Gondar – the media reports more than 80,000 people) that are displaced due to conflict and civil unrest. The number of IDPs is expected to increase and will create instability and put pressure on available resources.

Figure 7. Goat price trends in Mehoni Market, Tigray region



Source: FEWS NET

Nutrition: The nutritional status of children U5 currently has improved due to relatively better food access from households' own Meher 2018 production. The number of malnourished children admitted to the therapeutic feeding program (TFP) has shown slight decline in the both Tigray and Amhara regions in November 2018 compared to October 2018 and November 2017. In Amhara region, the November 2018 TFP admissions are lower by 2.4, 7.3 and 20.7 percent compared to the October 2018, November 2017 and the five-year average (2011-2016) respectively. In Tigray region, the November 2018 TFP admissions were lower by 11, 5 and 18 percent compared to October 2018, November 2017 and the five-year average (2011-2016), respectively. More than 59 percent of the January to November 2018 TFP admissions in the region were reported from North and South Gondar, North Wollo and Wag Himra zones. The number of hotspot priority 1 woredas for nutrition intervention identified by ENCU in Amhara region increased from 17 in July 2018 to 24 in January 2019. More than 62 percent of priority 1 hotspot woredas are from Wag Himra, North and South Gondar administrative zones of the TSG livelihood zone and North Wollo zones. This clearly indicates the presence of concerning food and nutrition gaps in the TSG livelihood zones and requires close following up and intervention.

Assumptions

The most likely scenario for the February to September 2019 period is based on the following area level assumptions:

Agroclimatology:

- Cumulative rainfall during the Belg season (February to May 2019) is likely to be average in Amhara and Tigray regions. Thus, Belg season-benefiting areas of northeastern Amhara and southern Tigray are expected to have near normal agricultural seasonal performance. Kiremt (June to September 2019) seasonal rainfall is expected to be average in both regions.

Agricultural Production:

- The 2019 Belg production is likely to be average following the anticipated average Belg rains in Belg-benefiting parts of both regions.
- The 2019 Meher production is likely to be average following the anticipated average kiremt (July to September 2019) rain season.

Markets:

- Livestock prices are likely to follow normal seasonal trends throughout the outlook period; however, prices are expected to seasonally decrease between February and April 2019 across most parts of northeastern Amhara and Tigray regions during the dry season.
- Currently, the supply for locally-produced staple foods, such as maize, wheat, and sorghum are relatively stable but have higher prices. From March 2019 onwards, staple food prices are expected to atypically rise sharply due to early depletion of stocks, limited supplies from other regions due to road blockages, and trade instability because of security concerns, in addition to the continued devaluation of the Ethiopian Birr that has resulted in higher transportation costs.

Income Sources:

- Fire wood and charcoal production and sales used to be a source of income for many of the poor households in this livelihood zone. However, this practice was banned by the government in 2017 to prevent further environmental degradation so income from this source is expected to be below average.
- The number of IDPs is expected to increase and will create further instability and put pressure on the limited available resources.

Nutrition and Health:

- From historical trends, the recent history of disease outbreaks, and the presence of poor hygiene and sanitation practices, disease outbreaks such AWD and measles are anticipated in the TSG livelihood zones particularly during the dry season of the outlook period.
- TFP admission are expected to show an increasing trend in the TSG livelihood zone during the upcoming lean season.

Humanitarian Assistance:

- Most parts of northeastern Amhara and Tigray regions including TSG are chronically food insecure and resource transfers through the Productive Safety Net Program (PSNP) are expected to take place following the typical schedule from January to June 2019.

Most Likely Food Security Outcomes

Current household food stocks in TSG livelihood zone are likely to deplete earlier than normal due to below average 2018 Meher production. Poorer households are likely to exhaust their stocks before the start of the normal lean season in March 2019 and will start to depend on market purchases to meet their food requirements. Households will continue selling of some of their remaining livestock holdings and are also expected to generate some income from local wage labor which will mainly be spent on food purchases. Thus, poor households in the northeastern Amhara and Tigray regions of the TSG livelihood zone will minimally meet their food requirements but will be unable to cover some essential non-food needs through February 2019 and remain in Stressed (IPC Phase 2).

After February 2019, and during the peak of the lean season from June to August 2019, most households will completely exhaust their stocks from 2018 but will continue selling some of their remaining livestock. They will take advantage of available agricultural labor opportunities including labor migration to get cash income to purchase staple food and non-food needs. Prices of staple foods will likely rise beyond the purchasing power of poor households and they will likely shift to cheaper staple foods and reduce meal frequency. Thus, with the early exhaustion of stocks from the 2018 Meher harvests, food security is expected to deteriorate from Stressed (IPC phase 2) in February 2019 to Crisis (IPC Phase 3) between March and September 2019 in Wag Himra Zone of Amhara region and between June and September 2019 in Southern Tigray region.

EVENTS THAT MIGHT CHANGE THE OUTLOOK

Table 2. Possible events over the next eight months that could change the most-likely scenario.

Area	Event	Impact on food security outcomes
National	New politically motivated, ethnic, or religious conflict events in areas already facing intercommunal violence and new regional border areas	- Restricted access to livelihood activities and household displacement would lead to restricted food access. - Restricted food commodity movement from surplus producing western to food deficit eastern parts of the country parts of the country would lead to limited food access
Somali and Afar regions	Increased tensions between Afar and Somali ethnic groups	Increased tensions would affect the road to the Djibouti port which would in turn affect the amount of imported food and non-food items to Ethiopia that would lead to increased costs of imported items, including fuel. This could also lead to a delay in humanitarian assistance transportation and delivery coming through the Djibouti port.
Southern and southeastern Agropastoral areas	Well below-average March to May <i>Gu/Gena</i> Karan rainfall.	Very poor <i>Gu/Gena</i> rains could result in significantly below average harvests and livestock body conditions leading to below average income from crop sales, livestock and livestock products. Poor household's food security would further deteriorate between June and September 2019.

ABOUT SCENARIO DEVELOPMENT

To project food security outcomes, FEWS NET develops a set of assumptions about likely events, their effects, and the probable responses of various actors. FEWS NET analyzes these assumptions in the context of current conditions and local livelihoods to arrive at a most likely scenario for the coming eight months. [Learn more here.](#)